



*Heracles was the baby son of Zeus and a mortal woman named Alcmene. Hera, Zeus's wife, was jealous of his love for Heracles, so she decided to get rid of the child.*

Hera conjured two huge snakes and sent them to kill Heracles. The serpents slid into the baby's crib but, unaware of the danger he was in, Heracles playfully grabbed them and accidentally squeezed the life out of them. Alcmene woke to find her baby holding two dead snakes and realized that Zeus had passed onto him a godlike strength.

*As Heracles grew, so did his superhuman strength.*

Heracles's power made him famous, and many people came to him for help. Creon, the king of Thebes, asked Heracles to defend his kingdom against an invading army. When Heracles drove away Creon's enemies single-handedly, the king allowed him to marry his daughter Megara.

Megara and Heracles were happily married and had three children. Hera, however, still hated Heracles and now saw an opportunity to punish him. She sent a curse that drove Heracles mad. In this state, Heracles did not recognize his wife or children and, believing them to be a threat, killed all four.